

27
INDIA 2.0

LET'S ADMIT it and not sugarcoat it. Things have gone from bad to worse between India and Pakistan in almost every way. The current state of affairs is ugly and hurts both nations. The trolls and the fake news on social media hurt too. Even more painful is the firing on the Line of Control (LoC) and the loss of lives on both sides, but not as much as the general breakdown in general civility between both countries. And let's not even get into how the mainstream media operates on both sides of the border.

First, policy: we have always welcomed India, in all matters related to the game. The love and welcome they've received on their previous tours of Pakistan – at least the ones I played in – have been on such a scale that I don't think Indian players will ever forget it.

Unfortunately – and I'm not talking about politics, diplomacy or proxy wars here – India has not reciprocated Pakistan's overtures.

There were days when Bal Thackeray's Shiv Sena alone would threaten our team when we toured. Now, with the Narendra Modi government in power at the centre, the hateful era of Thackeray and the Shiv Sena pales in comparison with the BJP (Bharatiya Janata Party) government's broader Hindutva policies towards Pakistan and Pakistan cricket.

I've seen it in my hotel room TV. I've seen it in the lobby. I've seen it from the team bus. I've seen it in the parking lot, the stands, the dressing room and the ground. The anti-Pakistan narrative in India has gained heights I could never imagine. It's almost as if the hatred against Pakistan – by India's political leadership, by the trolls on social media, by the anchors on television – is not organic, but organized.

Yes, I know tons of Indians who are simply awesome. They love the game of cricket for what it really is. These Indians agree with me when I say that you can't do away with Pakistan if you're an Indian, just like you can't wish away India if you're a Pakistani. But I feel that those voices are drowning out in modern India. If we can't be friends – because of our natural rivalry – then maybe we can at least be good neighbours?